

SECTION 301 INVESTIGATION ON FORCED LABOR

April 15, 2026

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Office of the U.S. Trade Representative
600 17th Street NW
Washington, DC 20508

Re: Request for Comments on the Section 301 Investigation of Acts, Policies, and Practices of Various Economies Related to the Failure to Impose and Effectively Enforce a Prohibition on the Importation of Goods Produced with Forced Labor (Docket number USTR–2026–0133)

The National Cotton Council (NCC), the central trade association of the U.S. cotton industry, requests the opportunity to testify in regards to the failure of other countries to enforce a prohibition on the importation of goods produced with forced labor.

The U.S. cotton industry operates in highly integrated and competitive global fiber and textile/apparel markets. Approximately 85% of U.S. cotton production is exported as raw cotton fiber, and much of the remaining 15% is exported as textile products in the form of yarn, thread, and fabric. Thus, nearly 100% of U.S. production is ultimately exported in some form.

We commend the Trump administration for recognizing the importance of eliminating goods made with forced labor from international supply chains and for seeking robust implementation by our trading partners of measures to prohibit importation of such goods in their own markets.

Forced labor, in all its forms, poses serious human rights concerns that warrant a sustained, coordinated effort by the international community. It also poses serious threats to the competitiveness and economic health of U.S. exporters and businesses, just as it poses the same threats to our trading partners and customers in foreign markets.

These competitive risks for U.S. exporters are exacerbated by inconsistent levels of regulation in key importing markets. This lack of regulatory alignment is a key obstacle for policymakers. Sustained international coordination to improve regulatory alignment is needed. The deployment of tariffs or other remedial measures that result from this investigation should be judiciously calibrated to mitigate the specific laws, acts or policies that are identified by USTR, with an eye to minimizing retaliatory harm to U.S. exports of cotton and cotton textile products.